

Chapter 1

Introduction

Chapter Outline

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Parental care is intimately associated with the complex and intricate coevolutionary relationships that exist among the core features of humanity: a large brain, flexible social cooperation, language, symbolic thought, and intersubjectivity (Hrdy, 2011). Humans are *flexible cooperative breeders*. That is, our children are not raised just by their biological mother; rather, fathers, grandparents, aunts and uncles, older siblings, and nonfamilial caregivers all may be involved in raising a child. Systems of care organize around children in a *flexible and opportunistic* way, sensitive to context, and we too, as clinicians supporting parents and children, are part of this flexible and cooperative network in its modern form.

Acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), the wider literature of relational frame theory (RFT), and the complimentary approach of compassion-focused therapy (CFT), are approaches emblematic of contextual behavioral science. These approaches have clear implications for parenting and the parent–child relationship, from finding meaning in parenting, to supporting the child’s emergence into the symbolic world, to responsive and attuned parenting, to supporting the child’s burgeoning perspective-taking abilities, to compassionate parenting. ACT, RFT, and CFT can be used to support parents in their enjoyment of and persistence in parenting well - in a flexible, workable, and compassionate way - even when psychologically difficult. Further, it can be used to understand and predict what kinds of parenting behavior might contribute to the development of psychologically flexible and prosocial children with broad and flexible behavioral repertoires. The research supporting these links is still in its infancy—there is much work still to be done—but the theoretical links are clear and consistent with existing research in areas such as attachment theory, metaemotion theory, theory of mind, and parental mind-mindedness.

When ACT, RFT, and CFT are integrated with existing literature across the relational–emotional, behavioral, and developmental areas a model begins to emerge: a model of how parental psychological flexibility can

Contact with the present moment including shared psychological presence

- Supports parental sensitivity and models contact with the present moment
- Parent is aware of changes in the parent-child relationship over time
- Supports parent responding proactively instead of reactively

Experiential acceptance of parent, child and relationship

- Supports adaptive and workable parenting
- Parent models acceptance and responds with acceptance to child emotion
- Parent is accepting of changes in the parent-child relationship
- Parent responds to emotions as opportunities for closeness and learning

Flexible languaging

- Parent and child play flexibly with language, e.g. pretend play, fiction and language games
- Relational framing abilities are supported in everyday interactions
- Parent develops flexible and workable parenting rules (tracks)
- Parent supports child in developing flexible and workable rules (tracks)

Flexible perspective taking

- Parent is aware of the child's ongoing psychological experience (other-as-process) and responds to the child as having a perspective of their own (other-as-context) and this supports sensitive, responsive parenting
- Parent can shift moment to moment from the dynamic, changing relationship (us-as-process) to the enduring relationship in time (us-as-context) and see challenges as part of development
- Parent models perspective taking and discusses perspective taking in everyday life

Values and supporting child proto-values

- Parenting is grounded within parenting values, supporting sensitive, responsive parenting and adaptive parenting behavior
- Parent lives values in other life domains at the same time as parenting, supporting parental wellbeing, exposing the child to a range of experiences and modelling valued living
- Parent supports developmentally appropriate experimentation
- Parent describes the child's enjoyment and prosocial behavior verbally, supporting the development of proto-values

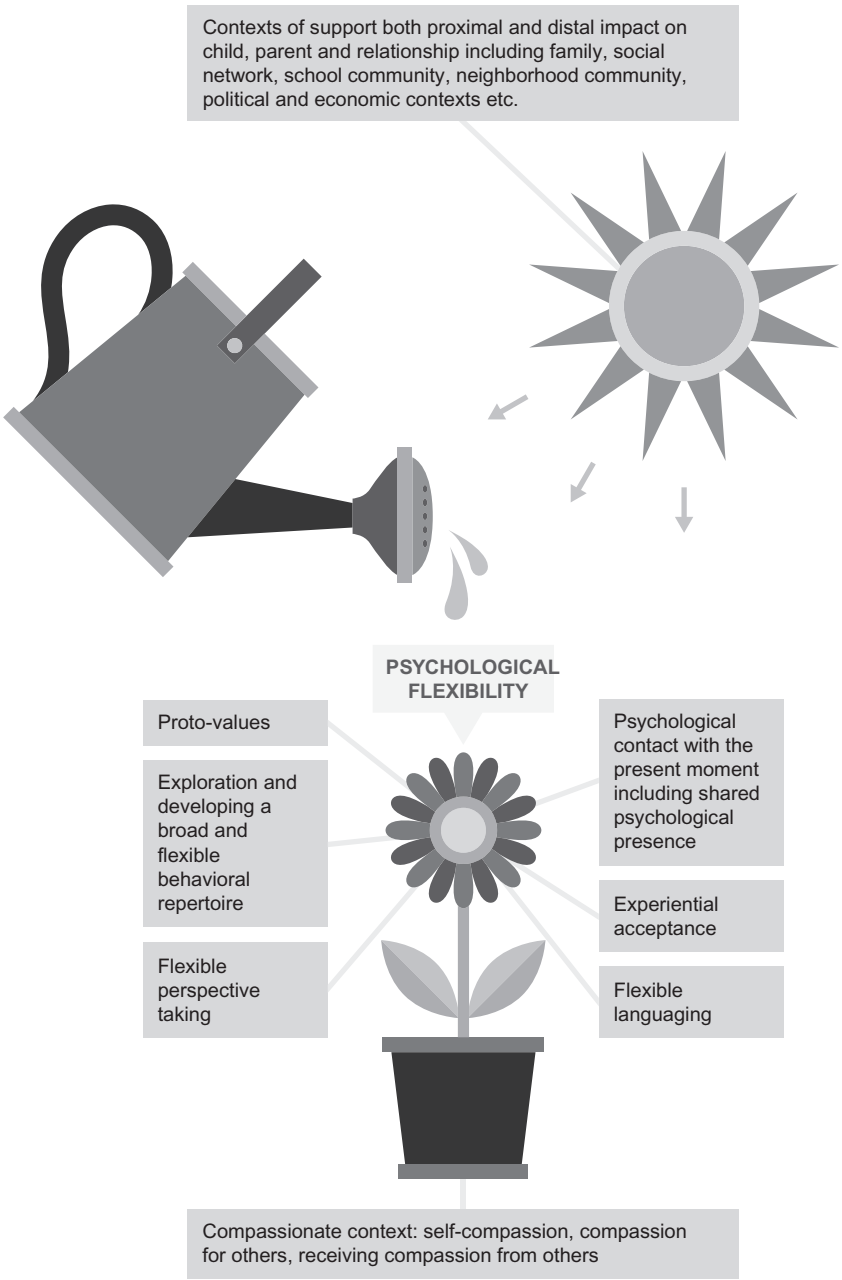
Compassion for parent and child

- Parent models self-compassion, compassion for others and receiving compassion
- Parent shows compassion for the child; sensitively responding to the child's expressions of distress and suffering

Committed action and exploration

- Parent adopts a flexible, experiential parenting stance discovering what works
- Parent adopts a sensitive and responsive parenting style
- Parent provides positive reinforcement for a variety of adaptive behaviors; including shaping behaviors
- Parent reinforces effort, flexible experimentation and exploration
- Parent refrains from reinforcing dysfunctional child behaviors including coercion
- Parent refrains from hostile, intrusive or coercive parenting behavior
- Parent can persist, when functional, even in the presence of difficult private events in self and child

Nurturing psychological flexibility.



(Continued)

support parental interaction that, in turn, supports the development of a psychologically flexible child. If the therapy of ACT is a way of *intervening*—a kind of medicine when psychological health has been compromised—then flexible parenting is a way of growing psychologically flexible people *organically*, through ordinary day-to-day interactions. This relationship between parental psychological flexibility, parental behavior, and the growth of a psychologically flexible child is illustrated in the following diagram:

Applying the ACT/RFT lens to parenting leads us to emphasize the resilience of a flexible experiential approach to parenting with the parent discovering workable parenting solutions. This flexible, workable parenting style can be understood as an evolutionary approach (Hayes & Sanford, 2015; Hayes, Sanford, & Chin, 2017). It is parenting using the principles of evolution: variation, selection, and the retention of adaptive traits. Parents flexibly vary their behavior, experimenting with different approaches (variation), since some behaviors work and some do not (selection). The behaviors that work are selected and retained, that is, the parent uses them again (retention). If selected behaviors stop working parents again experiment, reintroducing variation into their parenting. Thus, parenting evolves over time, and evolves with the development of the child.

One key potential contribution of ACT, RFT, and CFT to parenting research and intervention is the ability to integrate an at times fractured scientific literature and scientific and clinical community. The field of parenting science and intervention is often split into two worldviews: the relational—emotional (including attachment theory) and the behavioral. However, an evolutionary, contextual paradigm is wide enough to contain both. Within this book we have done the best we can to move toward a united parenting science and intervention approach grounded within an evolutionary, contextual paradigm. The ACT, RFT, and CFT communities are uniquely posed to bring about this change, with an emphasis on an evolutionary approach, strong background in basic behavioral science, grounding within attachment literature (CFT), and basic concepts that easily relate to core components of the relational—emotional literature including shared psychological contact, perspective taking, and compassion.

In this book you will find theory, research, practical hands-on knowledge, experiential exercises, metaphors, and clinical case studies. You will find information for beginners—for novices in acceptance and commitment therapy as well as for novices in parenting intervention—and you will also find in-depth discussion for seasoned ACT therapists and academics.

This book is divided into the following three sections:

1. Theoretical and scientific background.
2. The bedrock of clinical practice.
3. ACT processes.

The first section is the theoretical and scientific background. The first chapter briefly introduces all of the key theoretical frames used in this book through considering the evolution of parental care and parenting in the modern world. It also includes our *parent–child hexaflex*. All of the usual ACT components (as well as compassion) are present, but each in a more expansive and developmentally attuned way. The other two theoretical and scientific chapters are *Connect: The Parent–Child Relationship* and *Shape: Building a Flexible Repertoire*. They cover the emotional–relational and the contextual behavioral literature on parenting, respectively.

The second section, The Bedrock of Clinical Practice, covers the therapeutic relationship and case conceptualization, especially how to conduct a functional analysis and a formulation from an ACT perspective. This includes the application of functional analytic psychotherapy to the therapeutic relationship and the parent–child relationship.

The third section covers the ACT processes, with a chapter for each process within our parent–child hexaflex, and a final chapter on integrating ACT with other interventions. This is where we get practical, with experiential exercises and metaphors (including original exercises and metaphors) as well as case studies.

This book also covers the full spectrum of child development: from infancy through adolescence, along with a diversity of clinical presentations from anxiety to neurodevelopmental disorders, to conduct problems, and to postnatal depression and perinatal loss.

Navigate this book to suit your needs.

References

- Hayes, S. C., & Sanford, B. T. (2015). Modern psychotherapy as a multidimensional multilevel evolutionary process. *Current Opinion in Psychology*, 2, 16–20.
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- Hrdy, S. B. (2011). *Mothers and Others*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press.